

Case Study: Belichick and Game-Plan Football

A defense rebuilt every week to take away one thing, an offense that changed shape to match, and a coach who treated every situation as a rehearsed one

Atlanta, February 3, 2019, the fourth quarter of Super Bowl LIII. The Los Angeles Rams scored 32.9 points a game that season, second-most in the league, with a 33-year-old head coach, Sean McVay, who was being called the brightest offensive mind in football. They have three points. Their punter will kick nine times tonight, once for a Super Bowl-record 65 yards. On the sideline, their quarterback, Jared Goff, will later describe his evening in four words: “We were completely guessing.” McVay’s verdict is shorter: “I got out-coached.”¹ The New England defense on the field has no Hall of Fame pass rusher and no shutdown superstar. What it has is a plan that existed for exactly one week, built to take one offense apart, and a head coach, Bill Belichick, who had been building plans like it for more than thirty years. How do you make a great offense guess? And what did it cost New England to do it?

You’ll be able to:

- Explain what a **game-plan defense** is, how it differs from a defense that runs one system every week, and why it always comes with a bill that the defense chooses in advance.
- Break down Belichick’s three signature Super Bowl defensive plans (Super Bowl XXV against Buffalo’s K-Gun, Super Bowl XXXVI against Marshall Faulk’s Rams, and Super Bowl LIII against McVay’s Rams) and say, for each one, what was taken away and what was conceded.
- Describe how the Patriots’ offense changed shape to fit its players and each week’s opponent (the 2007 spread, the 2010–2012 two-tight-end sets, the run-first 2018 playoffs), and read that shape-shifting in data.
- Break down the final play of Super Bowl XLIX: the clock, the personnel, the formation, and the practice-field rep that decided it.
- Recognize the situational habits (end of the half, the clock, fourth down, the rulebook) that made the Patriots unusually good in close games, and test a team for them on Sunday.

i You’ll need

- **Dynasties and Counterpunches:** the Patriots’ place in the 2000–2016 arms race (the 2007 spread, the move tight end and the two-tight-end dilemma, the Giants’ four-man rush that beat them twice) and the 2009 fourth-and-2. This chapter zooms in on the coach.
- **The Game Plan: A Week Inside an NFL Building:** what a game plan and a tendency report are, how the week is built, and the principle “take away their best thing” with its bill. Here you’ll see that principle used at the highest stakes.
- Helpful too: personnel groupings and substitution matching from Personnel Groupings; man and zone coverage, nickel and dime from A First Look at Defense; and the bracket from Man Coverage.

How to read the diagrams. Offense is blue circles, defense orange squares, and *left* and *right* are always the offense’s. Q is the quarterback, R the running back, Y and U tight ends, X and Z the outside receivers and H a slot receiver; C is the center. On defense, E and T (and N, a nose tackle) are linemen; S, M and W are the Sam, Mike and Will linebackers (B is a second inside linebacker); \$ is the nickel back, D a sixth defensive back, CB the cornerbacks, FS and SS the safeties. Dotted lines join a man-coverage defender to his receiver, dashed orange arrows are a defender’s reaction, and brown dashes are the throw. A **red ring** marks the opponent’s “best thing”, the target of the plan; a **purple ring** marks a defender the plan moved or gave a special job. Every diagram is illustrative: built from the published accounts of each plan and typical alignments of the era, not traced from the coaches’ film.

¹Goff (“We were completely guessing”) and McVay (“I got out-coached”): Ben Volin, “Unpredictable Patriots defense was in the zone,” *Boston Globe*, Feb. 4, 2019: <https://www.bostonglobe.com/sports/patriots/2019/02/04/unpredictable-patriots-defense-was-zone/9XgMQoHp6f7nrTqbGdPUyI/story.html>. Johnny Hekker’s nine punts, including a Super Bowl-record 65-yarder: “Super Bowl LIII,” Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LIII. The Rams’ 32.9 points per game and second-best EPA per play in 2018: course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (regular season).

The problem: eleven defenders can't stop everything

Start with arithmetic. A defense has eleven players. An offense can put five receivers into a pattern, run in six or seven different gaps, throw short or deep, to either side. No arrangement of eleven people covers all of that. Every coverage you met in Part 6 has holes, and What Beats What is a catalogue of where they are. So every defense, every snap, is choosing what to be weak against.

Most defenses make that choice once, in the off-season. They pick a system, say Pete Carroll's single-high Cover 3 or Tony Dungy's Tampa 2, and they get very good at it. The holes are known, but the players have repeated the system thousands of times, so they play it fast and without mistakes, and the coaching is about doing the same thing better. "We're going to do what we do" is a real philosophy, and it has won Super Bowls: 11-04 tells how Seattle's 2013 defense won one with a system so simple that its players could play it at full speed.

Bill Belichick made the choice every week instead. That is the idea at the heart of this chapter, the **game-plan defense**: a defense rebuilt for each opponent, rather than run the same way every week. The staff decides what this particular offense most needs (a player, a concept, a part of the field), designs alignments and coverages to take it away, and chooses in advance what it will concede instead. The front, the coverages, even the personnel groups can change from Sunday to Sunday. The player who learned Belichick's defense in training camp did not know, in September, what he'd be doing in December. "Our philosophy is always, we're going to give them something a little bit different," is how Josh Boyer, then the Patriots' cornerbacks coach, put it after Super Bowl LIII.²

Belichick didn't invent the idea. Coaches have always prepared for opponents, and the phrase "make them beat you left-handed" is older than he is. What he did was make it the *whole* method, for longer and at a higher level than anyone else: the defense had no fixed identity to protect, only a process. Michael Lombardi, who worked with him in Cleveland and New England, added the refinement that runs through every plan in this chapter: Belichick "doesn't take away what the opponent does best, but what their individual players do best."³ The target is usually a *person*.

! Why it exists: the game-plan defense

What it solves. A defense with one system has one set of holes, and by mid-season every opponent has a tendency report that lists them. A defense that changes each week has no stable holes to scout: the opponent prepares for the defense it saw on film and meets a different one. And because the plan is aimed at *this* offense's best thing, it attacks the part of the opponent that matters most rather than playing the averages.

What it costs. Three. First, learning: a new plan every week means meetings, installs and practice time spent on things that will never be used again, and players who must be smart enough to absorb them. Belichick's teams famously valued versatile, coachable players over pure athletes for exactly this reason. Second, execution: a defense running something new is more likely to blow a coverage than one running its thousandth rep of the same call. Third, the bill itself: every defender aimed at the best thing is taken away from somewhere else, and the plan only works if the thing it concedes really is less dangerous.

Where the habit came from

Some of this is family history. Belichick's father, Steve Belichick, was an assistant coach and scout at the Naval Academy for more than thirty years and wrote a textbook on the subject, *Football Scouting Methods* (1962). As a boy in Annapolis, Bill sat with him while he broke down film of Navy's opponents, learning to see a game as a set of habits that could be listed and attacked.⁴ He started in the NFL in 1975 as a \$25-a-week assistant in Baltimore, coached special teams and linebackers for the Giants under Ray Perkins and then Bill Parcells, and was the Giants' defensive coordinator from 1985 to 1990, winning two Super Bowls. He was head coach of the Cleveland Browns from 1991 to 1995 and of the New England Patriots from 2000 to 2023, where he won

²"How Bill Belichick outcoached Sean McVay in Super Bowl LIII," *The Washington Post*, republished by the *Bangor Daily News*, Feb. 4, 2019: <https://www.bangordailynews.com/2019/02/04/sports/how-bill-belichick-outcoached-sean-mcvey-in-super-bowl-liiii/> (Boyer's "Our philosophy is always..."; the staff's conclusion that the Rams "specialized in 'man beaters'"; the switch to zone after a season of man; two linebackers walked up to the line, "effectively employing a six-man defensive line"; Jonathan Jones moved to a safety-type role midweek and dropping to the middle when Goff expected a blitz).

³Michael Lombardi, "The Belichick Way," *The Ringer*, Feb. 1, 2017: <https://www.theringer.com/2017/02/01/nfl/bill-belichick-game-plan-new-england-patriots-super-bowl-li-f25cf7de09e0>.

⁴David Halberstam, *The Education of a Coach* (Hyperion, 2005), on Steve Belichick's scouting career at the Naval Academy, his book *Football Scouting Methods* (Ronald Press, 1962), Bill Belichick's childhood film sessions with him, and Belichick's first NFL job with the Baltimore Colts in 1975 at \$25 a week. Steve Belichick's 33 years on Navy's staff (1956–1989): "Navy coaching legend Steve Belichick dies at the age of 86," *Patriots.com*, Nov. 2005, <https://www.patriots.com/news/navy-coaching-legend-steve-belichick-dies-at-the-age-of-86-151796>. The \$25 a week (after a short unpaid start, under Ted Marchibroda): *CNBC*, Jan. 31, 2019, <https://www.cnn.com/2019/01/31/bill-belichick-got-his-first-nfl-job-at-23-it-paid-25-dollars-a-week.html>.

six more.⁵

That last line hides the important point. The plans in this chapter come from three different eras of football: 1990, when the threat was a no-huddle passing attack; 2001, when it was a “Greatest Show on Turf”; 2018, when it was a young coach’s play-action machine. The defenses look nothing alike. The *method* is identical, and it fits in three questions:

1. **What does this offense most need?** Not what it does most often: what it can’t live without.
2. **What can we give it instead, that it would rather not take?** The concession has to be real, and cheap.
3. **What is the bill, and who pays it?** Which defender is alone, which part of the field is soft, which play are we willing to watch work?

Keep those three questions in mind; we’ll answer them for each Super Bowl in turn.

Super Bowl XXV: let Thurman Thomas run

The problem. The 1990 Buffalo Bills were the most explosive offense in football. They went 13–3, led the league with 428 points, and beat the Raiders 51–3 in the AFC Championship Game.⁶ Their weapon was the *K-Gun*, a no-huddle attack (the full story is in The 1978 Liberation and In-Game Adjustments): Jim Kelly in the shotgun, three wide receivers (Andre Reed, James Lofton and a third), a tight end who could block and catch, and Thurman Thomas, a running back who was as dangerous catching passes as running. Because the Bills didn’t huddle, the defense couldn’t substitute between plays. Whatever eleven players a defense had on the field when a drive began, it was stuck with them, and Kelly picked the play after seeing them.

The answer. Belichick’s plan started from the no-huddle. If you can’t substitute, you have to pick one personnel group that can survive every down, and he picked a light one: for most of the game the Giants had only two down linemen, Erik Howard and Leonard Marshall. Bill Parcells described it afterward as “a 2-4-5, or a 2-3-6”; at times there were six defensive backs.⁷ Then came the line that made his players think he had lost his mind. A week before the game he told them that if Thurman Thomas ran for 100 yards, the Giants would win. Linebacker Carl Banks called the idea “a collective brain fart.”

Here is the logic, in the three questions:

1. **What does Buffalo most need?** Kelly’s throws, especially to Reed and Lofton, and Thomas catching the ball in space. A no-huddle offense lives on completions: they keep the clock stopped (an incompletion stops it too, but gains nothing), keep the tempo fast and keep the defense tired.
2. **What can the Giants give instead?** The run. A run is one fewer pass. And every run kept the clock moving, which suited a Giants team that planned to win the game with its own offense, a ball-control attack that would keep Kelly on the bench.
3. **What’s the bill?** Thomas, running against a front with two linemen, would gain yards. Belichick bet that he couldn’t gain them fast enough, and he paid the bill on purpose.

And the passes the Giants *did* allow would be punished. Every linebacker and defensive back was responsible for hitting any Bill who caught the ball. “As soon as [Andre] Reed got the ball, he needed a helmet in his ribs,” Banks remembered.⁸

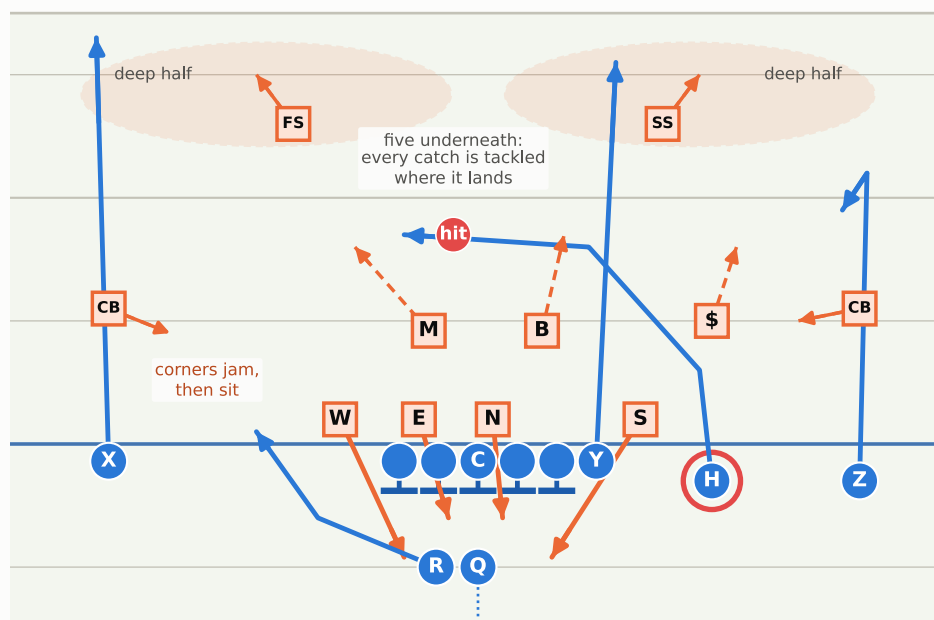
⁵Pro Football Reference, Bill Belichick: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/BeliBi0.htm> (Giants assistant from 1979, defensive coordinator 1985–1990, with Super Bowl wins after the 1986 and 1990 seasons; Browns head coach 1991–1995; Patriots head coach 2000–2023, six Super Bowl wins).

⁶“Super Bowl XXV,” Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XXV (Giants 20, Bills 19, January 27, 1991, Tampa Stadium; Buffalo’s 13–3 record, 428 points and 51–3 AFC Championship win; Thomas’s 135 rushing yards on 15 carries; the Giants’ Super Bowl record 40:33 time of possession; Norwood’s 47-yard miss).

⁷Michael Eisen, “Belichick’s gameplan,” Giants.com: <https://www.giants.com/news/belichick-s-gameplan> (Erik Howard and Leonard Marshall as the only down linemen for most of the game; Parcells’s “a 2-4-5, or a 2-3-6”; Belichick’s 100-yard prediction for Thomas and Carl Banks’s “collective brain fart”; every defender responsible for hitting the receiver; Buffalo 1 of 8 on third down; Reed, Lofton and Thomas 14 catches for 178 yards, with Lofton’s 61-yard catch the only completion longer than 20 yards).

⁸Jordan Raanan, ESPN, “Inside Super Bowl XXV: Whitney Houston’s anthem, Bill Belichick’s game plan and Scott Norwood’s miss,” Feb. 4, 2021, republished by ABC7 New York: <https://abc7ny.com/sports/inside-super-bowl-xxv-whitney-houstons-anthem-bill-belichicks-game-plan-and-scott-norwoods-miss/10314585/>.

Passing down: rush four, drop seven, hit every catch



The price: the inside run is open, on purpose

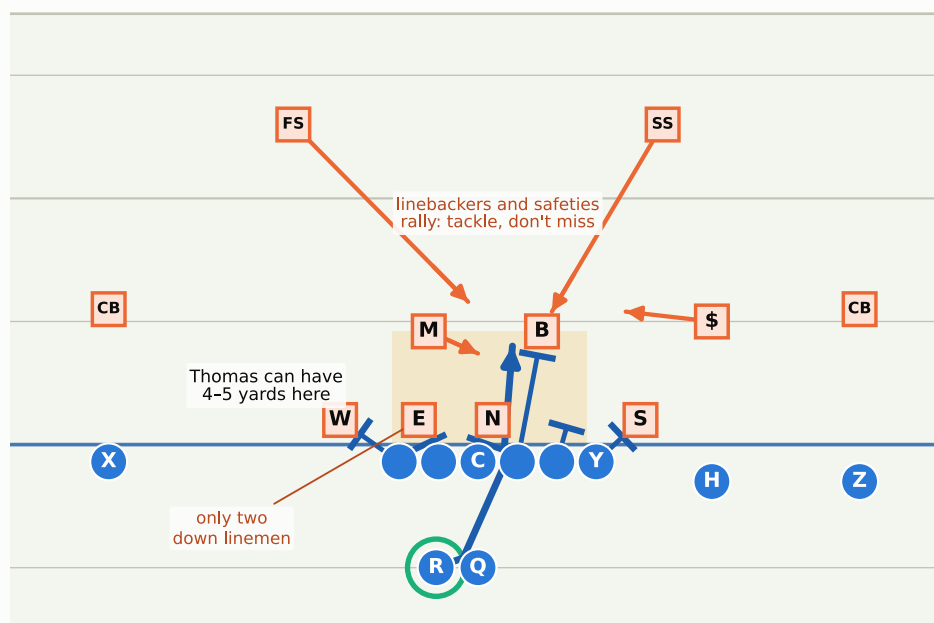


Figure 1: The Giants' Super Bowl XXV plan against Buffalo's K-Gun (illustrative). Top: on passing downs only four rush (two linemen and two outside linebackers standing up at the edges); the other seven drop, five underneath and two deep, so every short throw lands in front of a defender, and the plan's rule is to hit the receiver as the ball arrives (red badge on Reed's crossing route, H, red ring). Bottom: the price, chosen in advance. With only two down linemen the inside run is open (shaded); Thomas (R) can have four or five yards, as long as the linebackers and safeties rally and tackle before he gets more. Each of those runs is a play on which Kelly doesn't throw, and the clock keeps moving.

Thomas got his yards: 135 of them, on just 15 carries. The Giants won anyway, 20–19. Buffalo's receivers, Reed, Lofton and Thomas, combined for 14 catches and 178 yards, and only one of Kelly's passes, a 61-yard catch by Lofton, gained more than 20 yards; the Bills converted one third down in eight tries. And the Giants' offense did its half of the plan, holding the ball for 40 minutes and 33 seconds, still the Super Bowl record. The game ended with Scott Norwood's 47-yard field goal attempt drifting wide right.

Film room: New York Giants, Super Bowl XXV (1990 season)

January 27, 1991, Tampa Stadium. Watch the Giants' defensive front before each Buffalo snap and count the players with a hand on the ground: usually two. Then watch what happens after a short completion: a second and third defender arrive within a second of the catch, and the receiver goes down hard. Then watch Thomas's runs: he gets through the line easily and is met five yards downfield. That's the plan working, not failing.

What to notice: the plan conceded a statistic (Thomas's 135 yards) to win the game. A box score would tell you the run defense "failed". The plan's own scoreboard was different: how many times did Kelly throw, and how often did a throw turn into a big play? The handwritten plan, with sections such as "no-huddle adjustments," is now in the Pro Football Hall of Fame.⁹

Common misconception

"Take away their best thing" does not mean *stop* their best thing at any cost, or stop everything. It means: choose which of the offense's weapons you can live with, and point everything else at the one you can't. A game-plan defense that "gives up" 135 rushing yards and wins has not failed; it has paid the bill it chose. When you judge a defensive plan, ask what it was *trying* to concede before you count what it gave up.

Super Bowl XXXVI: two words, Marshall Faulk

The problem. Eleven years later Belichick was a head coach, and the opponent was even better. The 2001 St. Louis Rams, "the Greatest Show on Turf," scored 503 points and were 14-point favorites. Kurt Warner threw to Isaac Bruce, Torry Holt and Az-Zahir Hakim, and the whole machine turned on Marshall Faulk, a running back who was also one of the best receivers in football, the league's offensive player of the year three seasons running.¹⁰ The Patriots had already played them, in November, and lost 24–17. In that game Belichick and his defensive coordinator, Romeo Crennel, had put a linebacker on Faulk. "That didn't work out for us," Crennel said later, laughing.¹¹

The answer. Four years after the game, as a guest on ESPN's pregame show for Super Bowl XL, Belichick explained the plan in one sentence: "In Super Bowl XXXVI, our game plan was defined by two words: Marshall Faulk."¹² Every snap began with one question, *where is he?*

- **Faulk directly behind Warner:** expect a run, and play run defense.
- **Faulk offset to one side, or split out:** expect a pass. "He's not behind the quarterback; we're thinking jam the receivers." Press the wide receivers at the line to throw off the timing of Warner's throws, which in the Rams' system went to spots before the receiver had turned. And that "triggered the defensive ends, [Willie] McGinest, trying to hit Faulk and take him out of the game" as he released.
- **When we blitz, blitz over Faulk,** from his side, so that he has to stay in and block: "then our blitzers would get to the quarterback and we could force the ball out in a hurry."

In coverage, instead of a linebacker, a defensive back shadowed Faulk. And the Patriots played most of the night with five or six defensive backs: by one count, nickel or dime personnel on 54 of the Rams' 69 snaps, daring the Rams' coach, Mike Martz, to run.¹³ "It was in the game plan for us to hit Faulk no matter where he was on the field," McGinest said after the game.¹⁴

⁹Mark Mravic, "NFL History in 95 Objects: Bill Belichick's Super Bowl XXV game plan," *Sports Illustrated*, May 14, 2014: <https://www.si.com/nfl/2014/05/14/nfl-history-in-95-objects-bill-belichick-super-xxv-game-plan>. The "no-huddle adjustments" section: Nora Princiotti, *The Ringer*, Jan. 13, 2022, <https://www.theringer.com/2022/01/13/nfl/bill-belichick-bespoke-game-plan-bills-patriots-nfl-playoffs>.

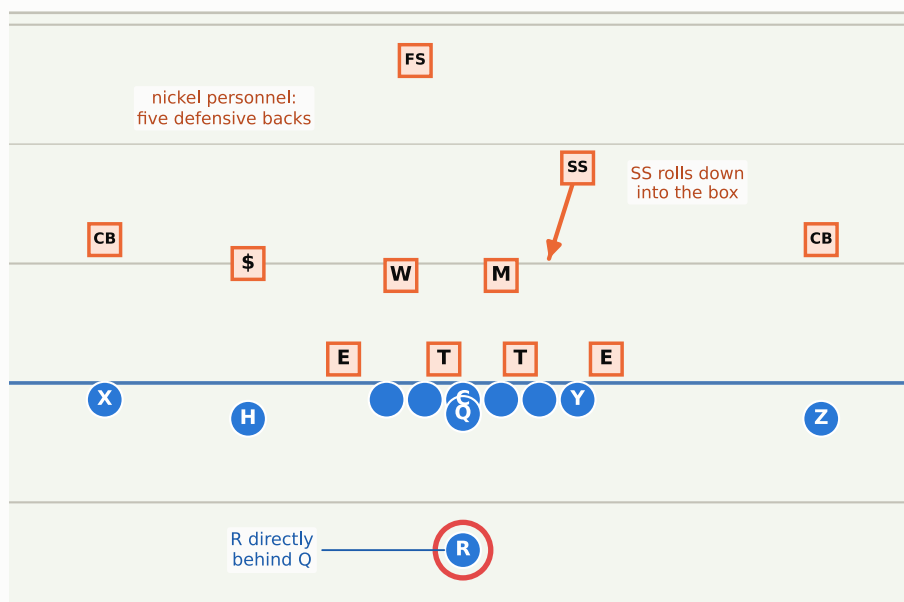
¹⁰"Super Bowl XXXVI," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XXXVI (February 3, 2002, Louisiana Superdome; Patriots 20, Rams 17; the Rams' 503 points in 2001 and the November 18 meeting, won by St. Louis 24–17; Faulk 17 carries for 76 yards and 4 catches for 54; Law's 47-yard interception return; the 1:21 final drive and Vinatieri's 48-yard field goal). Faulk's three straight AP Offensive Player of the Year awards (1999–2001): Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/F/FaulMa00.htm>. Score sequence: nflverse play-by-play. Vrabell's unblocked pressure on Warner on Law's interception: Robert Mays, *The Ringer*, Jan. 24, 2019 (full citation in the note on the dime count below). The 14-point spread: "Biggest upsets in Super Bowl history," NBC Sports Boston, <https://www.nbcsportsboston.com/super-bowl/biggest-upsets-super-bowl-history/684189/>.

¹¹Michael Holley, "Championship changes image of once-reviled Bill Belichick," *Boston Globe*, Feb. 4, 2002: <https://www.bostonglobe.com/sports/2002/02/04/championship-changes-image-once-reviled-bill-belichick/jyD9fpxNJLx7S7LASBcWSO/story.html> (a linebacker on Faulk in the first meeting; Crennel's "That didn't work out for us"; a defensive back shadowing Faulk in the Super Bowl).

¹²Belichick as a guest analyst on ESPN's Super Bowl XL pregame show (February 2006), quoted in Michael Hurley, CBS Boston, Aug. 16, 2017: <https://www.cbsnews.com/boston/news/video-bill-belichick-as-media-member-emerges-online>.

¹³Len Pasquarelli, ESPN.com, after Super Bowl XXXVI: https://www.espn.com/nfl/playoffs01/columns/pasquarelli_len/1322340.html ("nickel" or "dime" personnel on 54 of 69 snaps). Counts differ: Robert Mays, "Ten Observations From the Last Rams-Patriots Super Bowl," *The Ringer*, Jan. 24, 2019, reports

Faulk behind the quarterback: think run



Faulk offset: jam the receivers, hit Faulk

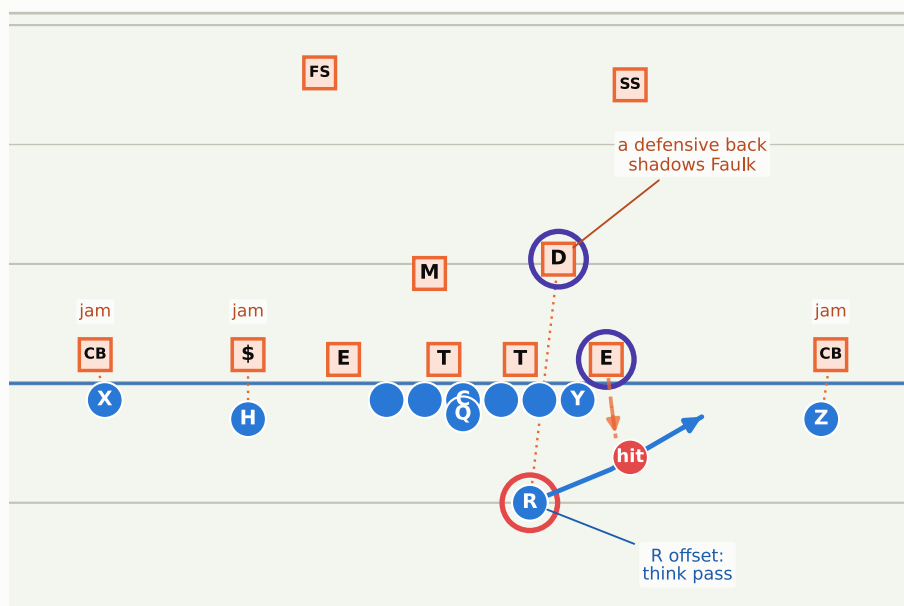


Figure 2: The Patriots' Super Bowl XXXVI plan: everything keyed on where Marshall Faulk (R, red ring) lined up (illustrative). Top: Faulk directly behind Warner (Q) is a run alignment, so New England plays run defense: the strong safety rolls down into the box and the nickel defense fits its gaps. Bottom: Faulk offset to the side is a pass alignment. The corners and the nickel press the receivers at the line to break the timing of the Rams' throws; the defensive end on Faulk's side (E, purple ring) attacks him as he releases (red badge), and a sixth defensive back (D, purple ring) shadows him in coverage instead of a linebacker. Dotted lines are man assignments.

Faulk's line looks ordinary: 17 carries for 76 yards, four catches for 54. But he never scored, never broke the long play the Rams' offense was built on, and spent the game being hit. New England's first points came from the defense: in the second quarter linebacker Mike Vrabel, rushing from the edge, got to Warner as he threw toward Isaac Bruce, and Ty Law returned the interception

a Fox broadcast graphic, shown with 6:09 left in the fourth quarter, of five or six defensive backs on 25 of 40 Rams plays, so it covers only part of the game: <https://www.theringer.com/2019/01/24/nfl/10-observations-rams-patriots-super-bowl-xxxvi-bill-belichick-tom-brady>.

¹⁴Geoff Hobson, "Patriotic defense," Feb. 4, 2002, reproduced on Bengals.com: <https://www.bengals.com/news/patriotic-defense-730932> (McGinest: "It was in the game plan for us to hit Faulk no matter where he was on the field"; Crennel: "We felt they would be ready for man coverage, since we gave them a lot of man the first time").

47 yards for a touchdown. The Rams had three points after three quarters and trailed 17–3. They rallied to tie it at 17. Then New England got the ball at its own 17 with 1:21 left and no timeouts, and the other half of this chapter’s story, situational football, took over (more on that drive below). Adam Vinatieri’s 48-yard field goal won it as time expired, 20–17.

Notice what *didn’t* change from Super Bowl XXV. Different decade, different team, different opponent; but the same method. Buffalo’s best thing was the passing game, so the Giants conceded the run. The Rams’ best thing was one player, so the Patriots built the entire defense around finding him and hitting him, and conceded the rest. In the first meeting they had blitzed and played man; Crennel’s staff guessed the Rams would be ready for man again, and they didn’t give it to them.

Super Bowl LIII: take away the picture

The problem. Seventeen years after the first Rams Super Bowl, the second one. The 2018 Rams went 13–3, scored 32.9 points a game and were second in the league in EPA per play. Their offense, Sean McVay’s version of the Shanahan system (the Shanahan case study has the family tree), was a magic trick built on sameness. The Rams used 11 personnel (one back, one tight end, three receivers) on 93% of their snaps in 2018, by far the most in the league, often from tight formations with the receivers close to the line. From that one look they ran outside zone with Todd Gurley, and play-action passes that began exactly like outside zone. A defense couldn’t tell run from pass by the personnel, the formation, or the first step. And Goff had McVay’s voice in his helmet radio until 15 seconds were left on the play clock, helping him read what the defense showed.

New England’s staff found one more thing in the film: the Rams’ pass game was full of man-beaters, crossing routes and rubs designed to beat man-to-man coverage. And man-to-man was what New England played. In 2018 the Patriots played man coverage on 61% of charted opponent dropbacks, the highest rate in the league (the median defense was at 33%).¹⁵

The answer. The plan, put together by Belichick and Brian Flores (who called the defense that season), did two things at once.¹⁶

- **Up front, put the run out of business.** The Patriots walked two linebackers up to the line of scrimmage, effectively playing a six-man defensive line on early downs. Outside zone needs the offensive line to move defenders sideways and climb to the linebackers; with six defenders on the line, every gap was filled at the snap and there were no linebackers to climb to. Stop the run on first and second down, and play-action stops working, because nobody believes the fake on third-and-8. Gurley finished with 35 yards on 10 carries.
- **Behind it, take away the picture.** After a season of man coverage, New England opened in zone. It mixed one-deep and two-deep shells, man and zone, so that what Goff saw before the snap was a poor guide to what he’d face after it. Midweek the coaches moved cornerback Jonathan Jones into a safety-type role; Goff kept expecting him to blitz, and he kept dropping into the middle of the field. Up front, the Patriots varied which of the six rushed and which dropped, and ran stunts (rushers looping around each other) they hadn’t shown on film. Stephon Gilmore, the best cornerback, covered the Rams’ fastest receiver, Brandin Cooks.

¹⁵Course calculation: nflverse participation data for 2018 (`load_participation`, NGS-sourced), joined to play-by-play; regular-season dropbacks with a charted man/zone label, by defense. Personnel shares (the Rams’ 11 personnel, the Patriots’ 21 personnel) from the same file, all regular-season runs and passes.

¹⁶Ben Volin, *Boston Globe* (cited above for the Goff and McVay quotes), on Brian Flores running the defense, the blitzes, stunts and twists, and Rams tackle Andrew Whitworth’s “they played a little more zone, which was different from what they’ve done all season.” Gurley’s 10 carries for 35 yards: Wikipedia, “Super Bowl LIII”. Gilmore on Cooks: Washington Post account cited above. Flores’s title in 2018 was linebackers coach; the *Globe* and the *Post* both describe him as the defensive play-caller. Boyer was New England’s cornerbacks coach from 2012 to 2018: CBS Boston, “Cornerbacks Coach Josh Boyer Leaves Patriots To Join Brian Flores In Miami,” Feb. 2019, <https://www.cbsnews.com/boston/news/cornerbacks-coach-josh-boyer-leaves-patriots-to-join-brian-flores-in-miami/>.

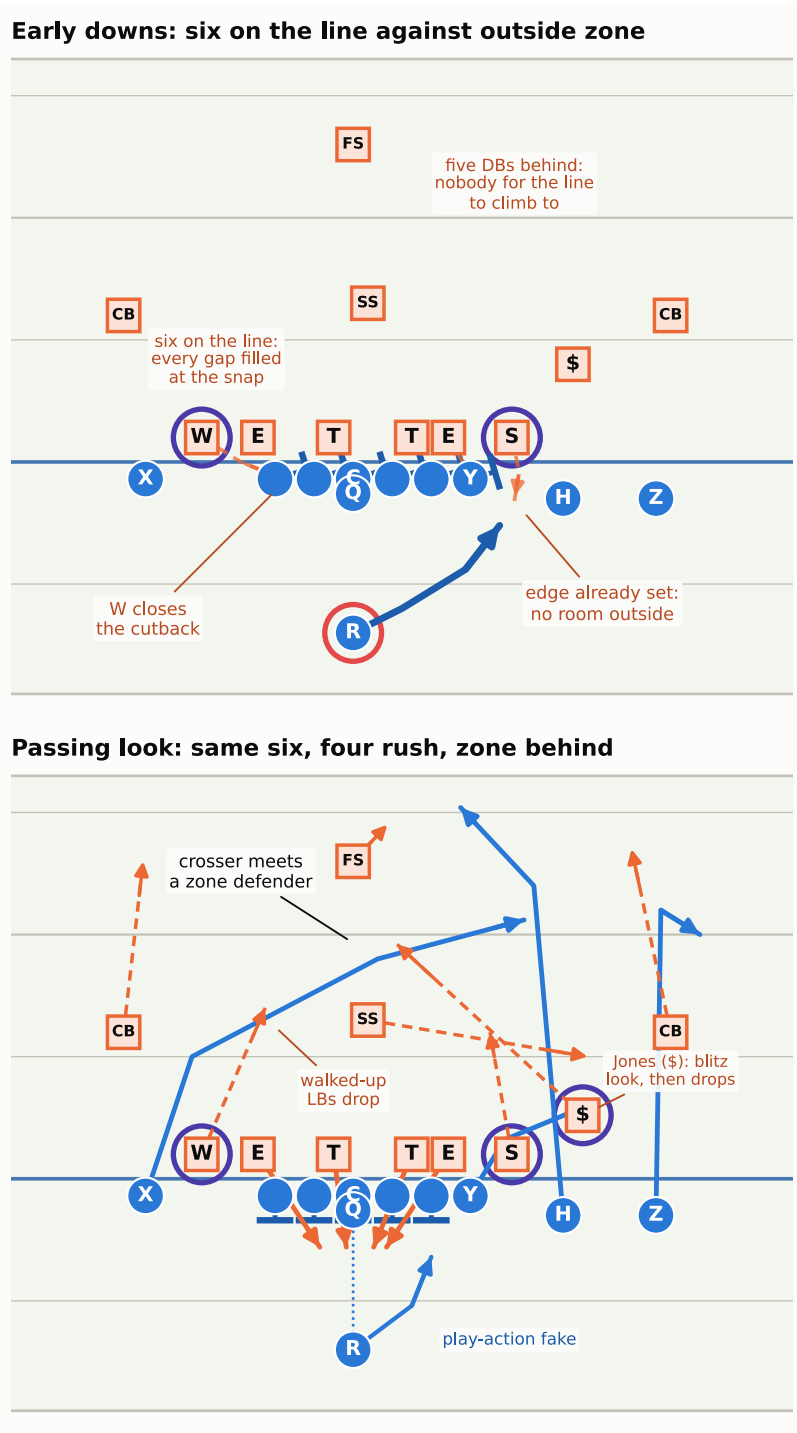


Figure 3: The Patriots' Super Bowl LIII plan against the 2018 Rams (illustrative; the Rams' 11-personnel set with tight splits, Goff under center). Top: early downs. Two linebackers (W and S, purple rings) walk up to the line, so six defenders are on the line of scrimmage and every gap is filled at the snap. Gurley's outside zone to the right (red ring) runs into an edge already set by the Sam and the end, and the backside linebacker (W) closes the cutback. Bottom: the same six before the snap, but on the throw only four rush. Both walked-up linebackers drop into short zones, and the nickel, Jonathan Jones (\$), who looks like a blitzer from the slot, drops to the middle of the field. Behind them is zone, not the man coverage New England played all season: the play-action crossing route by X (a man-beater) runs straight into defenders who are sitting in its path.

How far did the plan depart from New England's usual defense? The 2018 charting data (from nflverse's participation file, which labels each dropback's coverage and counts the pass rushers) lets us measure it. Figure 4 compares the Patriots' 2018 regular season with Super Bowl LIII.

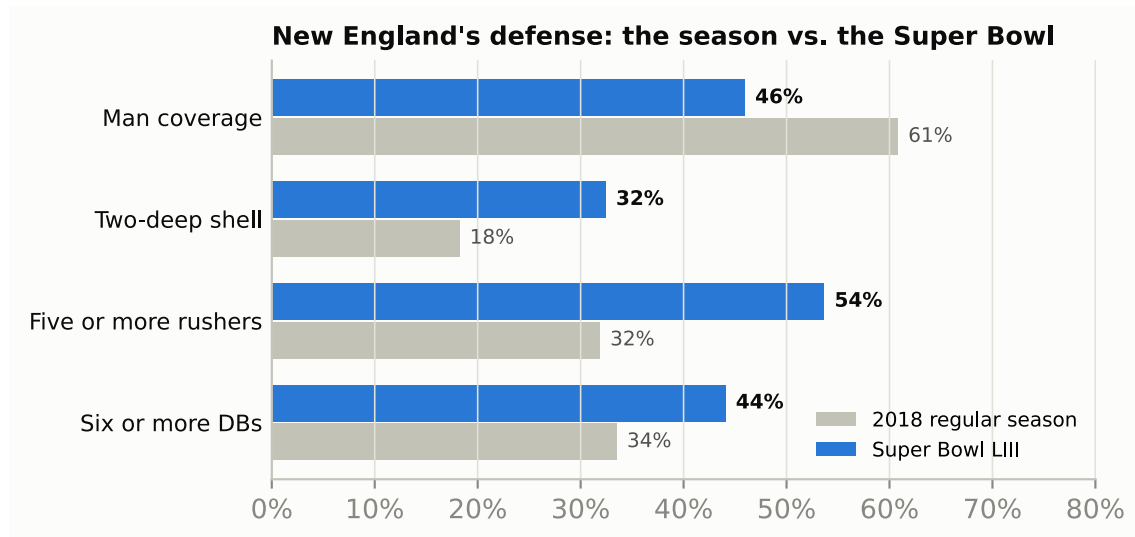


Figure 4: Super Bowl LIII against New England’s own 2018 regular season. Charted coverage and pass rushers on opponent dropbacks, and defensive personnel on all snaps (nflverse participation data). The Patriots, the league’s most man-heavy defense in 2018, played more zone and more two-deep shells in the Super Bowl, sent five or more rushers far more often, and had six or more defensive backs on the field more often. The Super Bowl numbers rest on one game (37 charted coverages, 41 dropbacks with a rusher count, 59 snaps), so treat them as a description of that night rather than precise rates.

Man coverage fell from about three snaps in five to fewer than half. The two-deep shells nearly doubled. And the “rush” went the other way from what the coverage suggests: five or more pass rushers on more than half of Goff’s dropbacks, against about a third in the season. (NFL Next Gen Stats, which counts differently, had the Patriots blitzing on half their snaps and pressuring Goff 14 times.)¹⁷ A defense that plays zone *and* sends extra rushers is giving up the safety net under its own coverage, and that’s the bill: with fewer players in coverage, a quarterback who reads it right has someone open, fast. The Patriots’ bet was that Goff, guessing, would not read it right in time. He went 19 of 38 for 229 yards with an interception and was sacked four times; the Rams converted 3 of 13 third downs, gained 260 yards and scored 3 points, their fewest under McVay (matched only once since, at Green Bay in 2023).¹⁸

The ending was the plan in one snap. With 4:17 left, the Rams trailing 10–3 and driving, New England, having mostly mixed and disguised all night, sent a six-man blitz with no deep safety at all, a Cover 0 call that left Gilmore alone on Cooks. Goff, under pressure, threw it up, and Gilmore intercepted it at the Patriots’ 3. A Stephen Gostkowski field goal made it 13–3. Sony Michel’s 2-yard run had scored the game’s only touchdown.

i Film room: New England vs. Los Angeles Rams, Super Bowl LIII (2018 season)

February 3, 2019, Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta. Watch the Rams’ first two series with the sound off and count the Patriots defenders standing on the line of scrimmage before each snap: usually five or six. Then, on each of Goff’s dropbacks, find the two players nearest the line who *don’t* rush, and the slot defender before and after the snap. **What to notice:** the pre-snap picture keeps lying. A defender aligned to blitz drops, a two-deep shell becomes one-deep, man becomes zone. “We were completely guessing,” Goff said. That sentence is the plan’s goal, achieved: McVay’s system was built to give his quarterback the answer before the snap, and New England’s plan was built to make the pre-snap answer wrong. The quarters-and-disguise toolkit behind it is taught in Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage.

¹⁷Danny Kelly, “Six Plays That Explain How Bill Belichick Outdueled Sean McVay,” The Ringer, Feb. 4, 2019: <https://www.theringer.com/2019/02/04/nfl/how-bill-belichick-outdueled-sean-mc-vay-patriots-rams-super-bowl> (blitzes on 50 percent of plays and 14 pressures, per NFL Next Gen Stats; five or more defenders up at the line; the six-man Cover 0 blitz and Gilmore’s interception on the last Rams drive). Chart and percentages in this section: course calculation from nflverse participation data for 2018 ([load_participation](#), NGS-sourced), New England’s regular season and Super Bowl LIII; “two-deep shell” = Cover 2, 2-Man, Cover 4 or Cover 6 on dropbacks with a charted coverage (blown and combination coverages excluded).

¹⁸“Super Bowl LIII,” Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LIII (February 3, 2019; Goff 19 of 38 for 229 yards, one interception, four sacks; 260 Rams yards; Gilmore’s interception at the Patriots’ 3 with 4:17 left; Michel’s 2-yard touchdown; Julian Edelman the MVP); the Rams’ 3 of 13 on third down and three points as their lowest total under McVay to that point; Kelly, The Ringer, cited above. The one later 3-point game (Green Bay 20, Rams 3, Nov. 5, 2023): [nflverse play-by-play, game 2023_09_LA_GB](#).

The pattern, side by side

Put the three plans next to each other and the method shows through the very different football.

	Super Bowl XXV (Giants, 1990 season)	Super Bowl XXXVI (Patriots, 2001)	Super Bowl LIII (Patriots, 2018)
Their best thing	Kelly's passing out of the no-huddle	Marshall Faulk, everywhere	One look that hid run and play-action; man-beaters
Taken away with	Light personnel that could play every down; five underneath, two deep; hit every catch	A key on Faulk's alignment; jam the receivers; hit Faulk; a DB on him; blitz over him	Six on the line against the run; zone and disguise instead of the season's man
Conceded on purpose	The run: "let Thurman have 100 yards"	The Rams' other runs and short throws; little help in the box	Fewer players in coverage; a corner alone on the final blitz
Result	Thomas 135 yards; Giants win 20–19	Rams 3 points through three quarters; Patriots win 20–17	Rams 3 points; Patriots win 13–3

Three things are worth noticing in that table. The concession is always *named*, usually out loud to the players. The plan always attacks something the opponent was proud of, so the opponent's coaches were least ready to lose it. And none of the three would have worked against the other two opponents: a two-lineman front against the 2018 Rams' outside zone would have been run over, and the 2018 plan's walked-up front would have been shredded by the K-Gun's spread passing game. That's the point. A game-plan defense isn't a scheme you can copy; it's a way of deciding.

It doesn't always work. In Super Bowl LII, after the 2017 season, Nick Foles and the Philadelphia Eagles gained 538 yards against New England and won 41–33; Belichick's decision to keep his starting cornerback Malcolm Butler off the field on defense was argued about for years and never fully explained.¹⁹ The method needs a plan that's right *and* players able to play it, and an offense with many good answers (Philadelphia's had a quarterback reading the defense, tight ends, running backs and trick plays all working) leaves less to take away.

Super Bowl XLIX: the last play

The most famous snap of the Belichick era happened on the other side of the method: not a plan's grand design, but one detail of one week's preparation, met by a decision under a running clock.

The situation. February 1, 2015, Glendale, Arizona. New England led Seattle 28–24. After a juggling 33-yard catch by Jermaine Kearse, Seattle had first-and-goal at the Patriots' 5. Marshawn Lynch, the most punishing runner in the league, ran for four yards to the 1 with 1:06 left. Seattle had one timeout; New England had two. And then, for about 40 seconds, nobody stopped the clock.

Two coaches and a clock. Pete Carroll's reasoning, which he explained afterward, went like this. Seattle had one timeout and needed one yard, and it wanted three chances at it. If it ran on second down and was stopped, it would have to burn its last timeout and then could run once more, maybe twice, with the clock nearly gone. A *pass* on second down, if incomplete, stops the clock for free, keeping the timeout for later. And New England had sent its goal-line defense, with only three defensive backs, onto the field against Seattle's three wide receivers: "It's not the right matchup for us to run the football, so on second down, we throw the ball," Carroll said, with the plan of running on third and fourth down.²⁰ Belichick, for his part, let the clock run instead of calling a timeout, which would have saved time for Tom Brady if Seattle scored. He said later that he had considered it, but that the Patriots' goal-line defense had come on at about the same time as Seattle's three receivers, and "in the flow of the game, that we were OK with where we were."²¹ On NFL Network's later documentary, he recalled looking across at the Seattle sideline, sensing hesitation, and telling his staff to stay in goal-line. The ball was snapped with 26 seconds left.

¹⁹"Super Bowl LII," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LII (February 4, 2018; Eagles 41, Patriots 33; 538 Philadelphia yards; Butler's benching).

²⁰"What went wrong on the Seahawks' final play?," NFL.com: <https://www.nfl.com/news/what-went-wrong-on-the-seahawks-final-play-0ap3000000467667> (Seattle's 11 personnel; New England's goal-line group with three defensive backs; Carroll: "It's not the right matchup for us to run the football, so on second down, we throw the ball," and the plan to run on third and fourth down). On saving the clock for all of Seattle's plays: Terry Blount, ESPN, Feb. 3, 2015, via ABC7: <https://abc7.com/post/carroll-throwing-was-part-of-the-plan/501284/>.

²¹Marc Sessler, "Bill Belichick explains no timeout at end of Super Bowl," NFL.com: <https://www.nfl.com/news/bill-belichick-explains-no-timeout-at-end-of-super-bowl-0ap3000000468110> (Belichick on WEEI: "We put our goal-line defense in probably around the same time they were sending in their

The preparation. New England's coaches had studied Seattle's goal-line passing game during the week, and one look stood out: two receivers stacked, one behind the other, close to the formation, with the front man running into the defender of the back man (a rub route) so that the back man could slip underneath on a quick slant. The defensive rule for it was simple. The defender on the front man jams him at the line, so the rub never happens. The defender on the back man doesn't give ground and jumps the slant. In practice that week, the scout team ran the play against a rookie cornerback, Malcolm Butler, who hadn't even been sure of a place in the goal-line package, and beat him for a touchdown. Belichick told him: if you see that formation, you can't give ground.²²

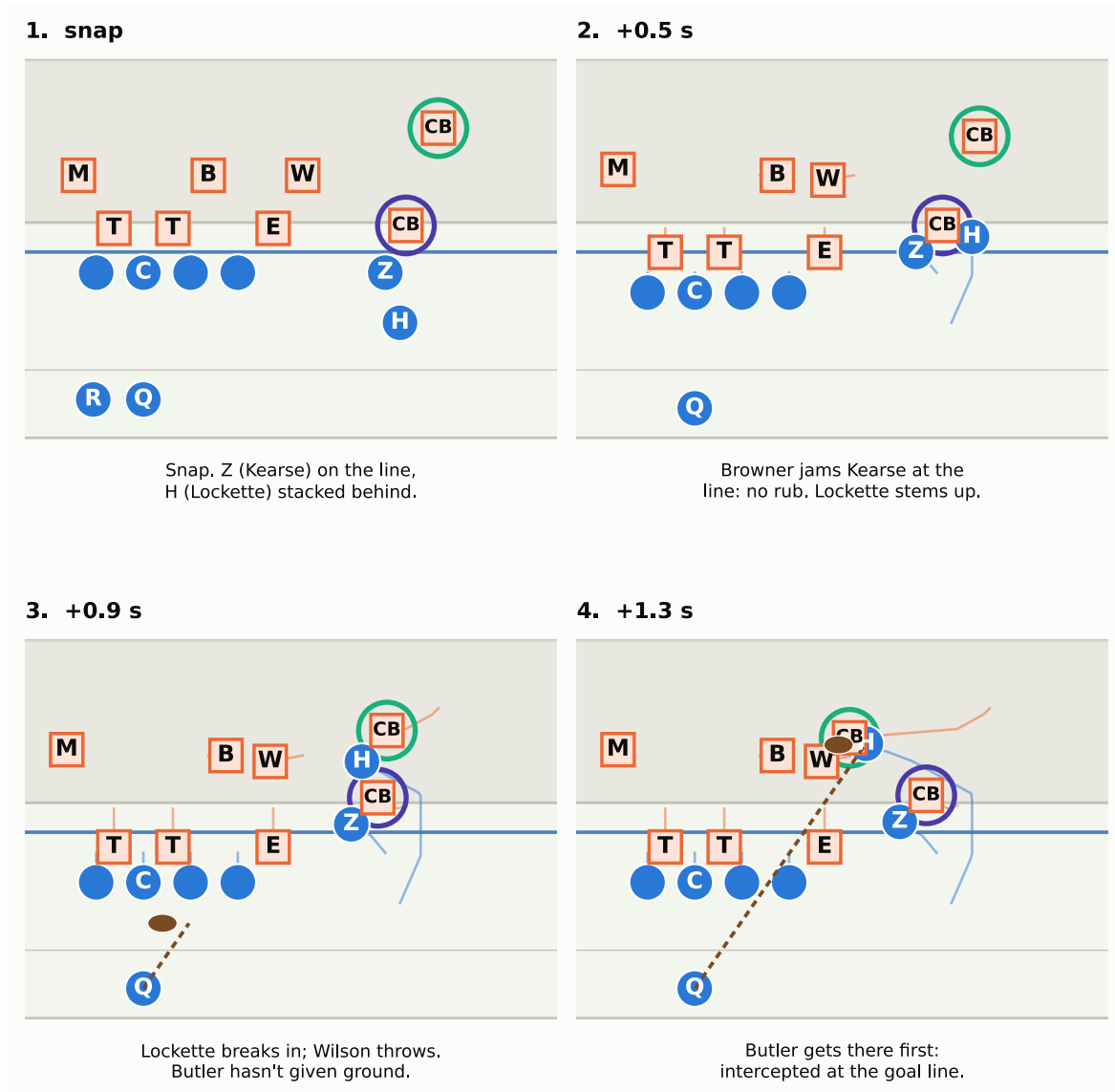


Figure 5: Super Bowl XLIX, second-and-goal from the Patriots' 1 with 26 seconds left: the final play (simulated, BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron, not recorded; alignment illustrative). Seattle has three receivers on the field; on the right, Kears (Z) is on the line and Lockette (H) stacked behind him. The grey area is the end zone. New England is in its goal-line package with three defensive backs: Revis on Baldwin (X, out of frame to the left), Browner (CB, purple ring) pressing Kears, and Butler (CB, green ring) off the ball on Lockette. (1) The snap. (2) Kears tries to cross Butler's path and rub him off Lockette, but Browner has jammed him at the line, and the pick never forms. (3) Wilson throws the slant. Butler, who has seen this formation from the scout team, has not given ground and is already breaking. (4) Butler arrives first and intercepts at the goal line.

multiple receiver group ... it just seemed like, in the flow of the game, that we were OK with where we were"). His later account of reading the Seattle sideline is from NFL Films' *Do Your Job* (2015).

²²Kevin Van Valkenburg, "How Malcolm Butler made the greatest play in Super Bowl history," ESPN, Dec. 8, 2015: https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/14286587/how-patriots-malcolm-butler-made-greatest-play-super-bowl-history-beat-seahawks (Ernie Adams's research on Seattle's goal-line formations; the practice rep in which the scout team, with Jimmy Garoppolo throwing to Josh Boyce, beat Butler; Belichick's instruction; Browner's assignment to jam the first receiver; Belichick's "Just play goal-line").

Seattle came out with exactly that look: Kearse in front, Ricardo Lockette behind him, on the right. Brandon Browner, lined up on Kearse, jammed him at the line, so Kearse never got across Butler's path. Butler, lined up on Lockette, didn't wait to see the route develop. He drove on the slant, beat Lockette to the spot, and intercepted Russell Wilson's pass at the goal line with 20 seconds left. "I remembered the formation they were in, two receivers stacked," Butler said. "I just knew they were going to [a] pick route."²³ New England won 28–24. Red Zone, Goal Line, and Short Yardage draws the stack rub itself, and why it beats man coverage near the goal line; here the point is the preparation. The play was a good play. It met a defense that had seen it, rehearsed it, and assigned one defender to kill the rub and another to jump the throw.

i Go deeper: was the throw a blunder?

"Worst call in Super Bowl history" was the instant verdict, and it's worth testing, because it is the kind of claim data can check. In the fourteen seasons before that Super Bowl (2001–2014, nflverse play-by-play, all games), teams snapped the ball from their opponent's 1-yard line 4,851 times. Runs scored a touchdown 55% of the time and were fumbled away 1.8% of the time; passes scored 51% of the time and were intercepted 2.9% of the time. So yes, a pass from the 1 was a little worse than a run on both counts. But not by much, and the averages hide what Carroll was buying: a pass that falls incomplete stops the clock and keeps his last timeout for later, which made three tries at the end zone possible instead of two. The decision was defensible; the outcome was the kind that happens about once in 34 throws from there, and it happened because the defense had prepared for that exact snap.

Belichick's own decision deserves the same test. Calling a timeout after Lynch's run would have stopped the clock at about a minute, so if Seattle scored, Brady would have had time to answer. Letting the clock run kept his goal-line personnel matched against Seattle's three receivers and kept Seattle hurrying. Analysts still argue about both choices. That's the honest lesson of situational football: good decisions and good outcomes are different things, and the rehearsed detail (a jam, a jumped slant) can matter more than either coach's clock math.

The chameleon offense

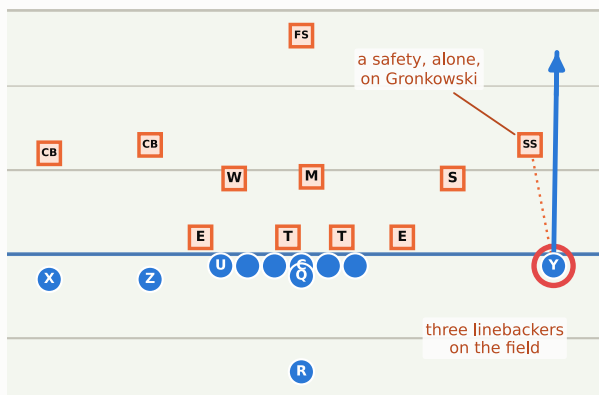
So far this chapter has been about defense, because that's where game-plan football started. But Belichick's offenses were built on the same idea, pointed the other way: *be whatever this opponent can least handle this week*. Dynasties and Counterpunches tells the three big shape changes as history: the 2007 spread (Randy Moss outside, Wes Welker in the slot, 589 points, then a record), the 2010–2012 two-tight-end offense with Rob Gronkowski and Aaron Hernandez, and the language underneath that made both possible, the Erhardt-Perkins system, in which one word names a concept that can be run from any formation and any personnel, so the offense can change its clothes without learning new plays. Here we look at the shape-shifting as a *game plan*, week to week.

Gronkowski and the 12-personnel dilemma

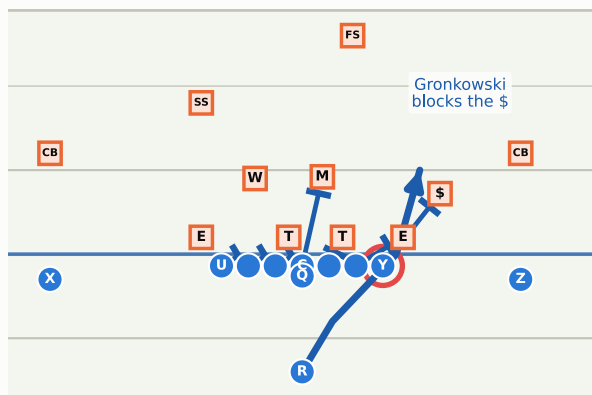
The two-tight-end offense of 2011 needed two rare players. After Hernandez was gone, from 2013, the Patriots showed the dilemma survives with one: Rob Gronkowski, 6-foot-6 and about 265 pounds, a tight end who could block a defensive end and outrun a linebacker. With him and a second, ordinary blocking tight end on the field (12 personnel: one back, two tight ends, two receivers), the defense has to choose its personnel before it sees the formation, and every choice leaves a hole.

²³Butler's quote: *Boston Globe*, Feb. 2, 2015: <https://www.bostonglobe.com/sports/football/2015/02/02/name-decides-super-bowl-malcolm-butler-does-job/LiVP49K7LDfMK9PwuyKylJ/story.html>. Down, distance, clock (Lynch's run at 1:06, the snap at 0:26, the interception leaving 0:20) and timeouts: nflverse play-by-play, game 2014_21_NE_SEA. Goal-line rates in the callout: nflverse play-by-play 2001–2014, all games, runs and passes snapped from the opponent's 1 (penalty plays and kneels excluded).

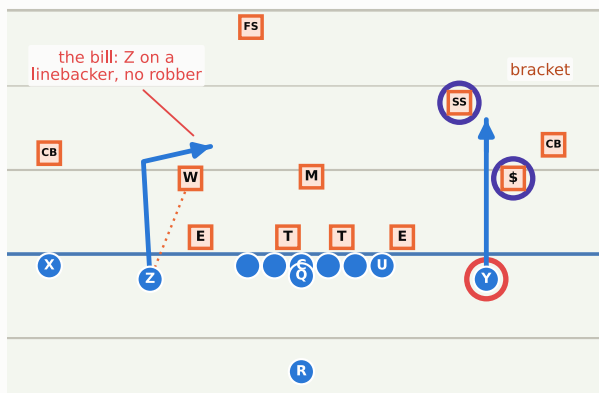
A. Base: split him out



B. Nickel: keep him in, run at the \$



C. The bracket: two on one



D. The defense's menu

Defense sends out... ...and the Patriots answer

Base (3 linebackers)	Split Gronkowski out: a linebacker or safety covers him alone
Nickel (5 DBs)	Keep him in-line: run at the nickel back
Bracket him	Throw to the others; run at a lighter box

Figure 6: The Gronkowski 12-personnel dilemma (illustrative; Gronkowski is Y, red ring; U is the blocking tight end). The defense picks its personnel first, then the Patriots pick the formation. A: the defense stays in base, with three linebackers, so Gronkowski splits out wide and a linebacker or safety has to cover him alone: the back-shoulder throw or the seam is there. B: the defense goes to nickel to cover him, so he stays in-line, and the run goes right at the 190-pound nickel back (\$), with Gronkowski blocking. C: the answer opponents settled on, a bracket, with a cornerback underneath and outside and a safety over the top (purple rings). It takes Gronkowski away, but it spends two defenders on one: the other receiver (Z, often Julian Edelman) gets a linebacker in coverage and nobody deep in the middle, and the run box has one fewer defender.

Panel D is the whole dilemma in three lines, and it's the same order-of-events trick as in 11-04: the defense commits its personnel before it sees the formation, so an offense with a player who is good at two jobs gets to pick which job he does *after* the defense has chosen. Panel C is the defense's way out, and it's pure Belichick logic turned against him: take away the best thing (Gronkowski) and pay the bill somewhere else. That's why the Patriots kept a receiver like Julian Edelman, quick enough to win against a linebacker or a nickel back on an option route, next to Gronkowski for most of the decade. The bracket on one created the matchup for the other.

Game by game

The deeper shape-shifting was weekly. A team with one identity runs and passes in roughly the same proportions every Sunday, adjusting for the score. Belichick's Patriots would throw on almost every early down one week and run on most of them the next, depending on what the opponent's defense couldn't handle. Figure 7 measures it.

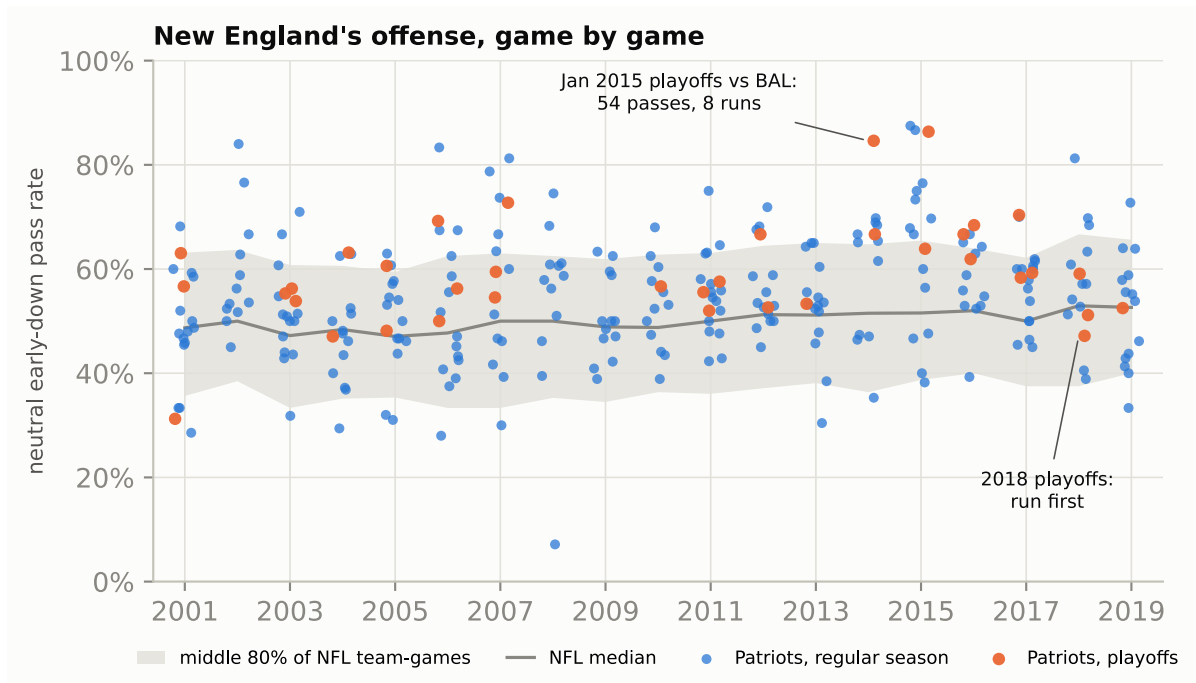


Figure 7: The chameleon, measured. Each dot is one Patriots game, 2001-2019 (blue: regular season; orange: playoffs): the share of plays that were passes on first and second down in neutral situations (win probability 20-80%, more than two minutes left in the half; games with at least 15 such plays). The grey band is the middle 80% of all NFL team-games that season and the grey line the league median. New England's games spread unusually far from one another; from 2001 to 2019 only one team's game-to-game pass rate varied more. Labelled: the January 2015 divisional game against Baltimore and the 2018 AFC Championship Game, in the playoff run when the offense turned to the run. (The AFC Championship Game against Indianapolis a week after the Baltimore game, a run-heavy rout, had too few neutral-situation plays to appear.)

Look at January 2015. In the divisional round against Baltimore, whose defense was strong up front and weak in the secondary, the Patriots threw 54 passes and ran 8 times, and won 35-31 (the game in which they also confused Baltimore with legal formations that made eligible receivers look ineligible, the trick Formation Rules explains). Eight days later, in the AFC Championship Game against an Indianapolis defense that couldn't stop the run, they ran it 39 times; LeGarrette Blount carried 30 times for 148 yards and 3 touchdowns, and New England won 45-7.²⁴ Same coach, same quarterback, same playbook language, nearly opposite offenses.

Or look at the end of the 2018 season. The Patriots had been a pass-first team, and in the regular season they used 21 personnel (two backs, with fullback James Develin) on 29% of their snaps, second-most in the league. In the playoffs they leaned on the run: 156, 177 and 156 rushing yards in their three games, with the rookie Sony Michel carrying the load, first against a Chargers defense that had just beaten Baltimore with seven defensive backs on 58 of its 59 snaps,²⁵ then against Kansas City and the Rams. The 41-year-old Tom Brady threw less, and the team won the Super Bowl anyway. Even the weather got a game plan: in a December 2008 game in Buffalo, in heavy wind, the Patriots ran 45 times and threw 11 passes, and in a December 2021 Monday-night game in Buffalo (told in 08-03) they threw three.

²⁴nflverse play-by-play: 2014_19_BAL_NE (Jan. 10, 2015, New England 35-31) and 2014_20_IND_NE (Jan. 18, 2015, New England 45-7), passes and designed runs counted from plays with a down; the 2018 playoff games 2018_19_LAC_NE, 2018_20_NE_KC and 2018_21_NE_LA (rushing yards); 2008_17_NE_BUF (Dec. 28, 2008). Personnel shares: nflverse participation data, 2018 regular season.

²⁵Next Gen Stats via NFL.com, "Chargers' speedy secret plan stopped Ravens," Jan. 2019: <https://www.nfl.com/news/chargers-speedy-secret-plan-stopped-ravens-0ap3000001008744> (seven defensive backs on 58 of 59 snaps in the 23-17 wild-card win at Baltimore, Jan. 6, 2019).

In Madden, a team's offense is its playbook: pick "Spread" or "Pro Style" and that's who you are. Real NFL offenses carry a far bigger playbook than any one game uses, and each week's game plan selects a slice of it for this opponent. The Patriots took that further than anyone: their system was a *language* (Erhardt-Perkins concepts that work from any formation) rather than a list of plays, so the slice could be almost anything. Fifty-four passes one week, thirty-nine runs the next, from the same quarterback and the same play-caller, Josh McDaniels, is not a team with an identity crisis. It's a team whose identity is the game plan.

Situational mastery

The third leg of Belichick's football was the one fans noticed least until the last two minutes: treating every *situation* (the end of a half, a lead to protect, fourth-and-short, a strange rule) as something to be studied and rehearsed in advance, like an opponent. Most of the plays below are told in full in The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down; put them side by side and they show a habit rather than a string of lucky calls.

- **Super Bowl XXXVI, 1:21 left, no timeouts, tied, own 17.** John Madden, on the broadcast, said New England should kneel and play for overtime. Belichick and Brady judged that short, safe throws to the sideline and the middle could move into field-goal range without risking a turnover, and that the Rams' prevent-style defense would give them exactly that. Nine plays, 53 yards, Vinatieri from 48 as time expired. The two-minute offense had been practiced for exactly this.
- **November 2003 at Denver, trailing.** Pinned at their own 1 with under three minutes left, down a point, the Patriots took an *intentional safety* to punt from the 20 instead of their own end zone, gave up two points, and won the game when the field position paid off.
- **Super Bowl XLVI, February 2012, leading 17–15.** With the Giants inside the 10 and about a minute left, Belichick told his defense to let Ahmad Bradshaw score, so that Brady would get the ball back with time. (Bradshaw tried to stop at the 1 and fell into the end zone; the Patriots lost anyway, but the logic was right.)
- **The 2009 fourth-and-2 at Indianapolis,** told in 11-04: the analytics favored going for it, the outcome didn't, and the decision was defensible.
- **The rulebook as a playbook.** In the January 2015 playoff game against Baltimore, the Patriots used the rules for reporting eligibility: a running back reported as ineligible and lined up where a receiver would stand, while a tight end, eligible, stood at left tackle. The Ravens couldn't sort out who could catch a pass; their coach, John Harbaugh, came onto the field to protest and drew a penalty; and for 2015 the league changed the rule (02-02 explains it).
- **Super Bowl XLIX,** above: a coach who let the clock run because he liked his defensive personnel more than he wanted the seconds.

Is "situational mastery" real, or is it a story told about a team with a great quarterback? Some of it is measurable.²⁶ In 2001–2019 regular seasons the Patriots outscored opponents by 0.84 points per game in the last two minutes of the first half alone, second in the league over those nineteen seasons (behind Pittsburgh). That's the "double score" habit: points just before halftime, then, if you deferred the opening coin toss, the ball again just after it. And in one-score games (decided by eight points or fewer) they went 86–43, a 0.667 winning percentage, the best in the league over the same seasons. Close-game records carry a lot of luck, and some of New England's came from having Tom Brady. But nineteen years of them is a long streak of luck.

The data fingerprint

If game-plan defense is real, it should leave marks in the data that a system defense wouldn't. Figure 8 tests three of them for every team, over the nineteen regular seasons from 2001 to 2019.

²⁶Course calculations from nflverse play-by-play, 2001–2019 regular seasons. End-of-half margin: points scored minus points allowed on plays in the last 120 seconds of the second quarter (all plays, including kicks and defensive scores), divided by games played. One-score games: final margin of eight points or fewer. Opponents' points: each team's points in a game minus its average in its other games that season. Top receiver: the receiver with the most receiving yards in his team's other games that season (at least six other games), his share of the team's targets in this game minus his share in the other games; games he missed are excluded.

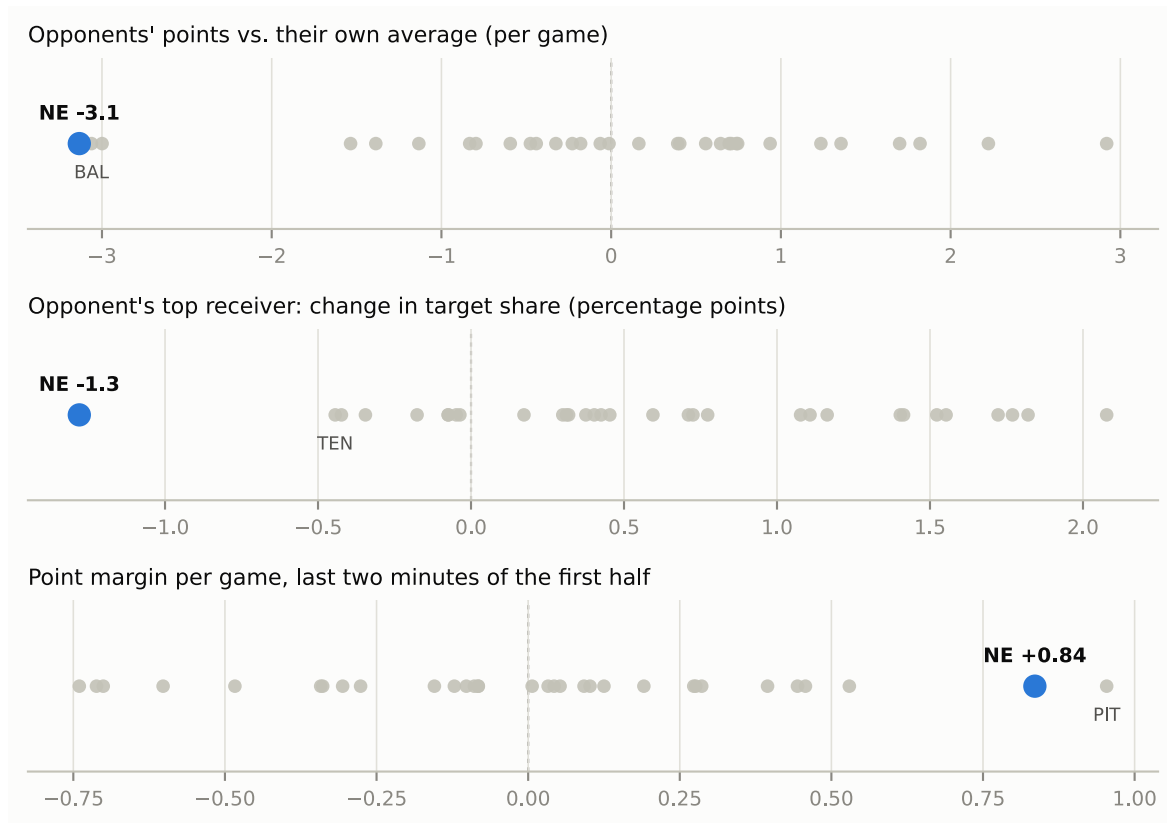


Figure 8: A Belichick-era fingerprint: every NFL team, 2001-2019 regular seasons (nflverse play-by-play), New England in blue. Top: how many points opponents scored against this defense, compared with what the same opponent scored in its other games that season (negative is better). Middle: the opponent's top receiver (most receiving yards in his team's other games that season), and his share of his team's targets against this defense, minus his share in the other games. Most defenses barely change it; New England cut it the most. Bottom: point margin per game in the last two minutes of the first half.

Read it as three separate claims, each with its own caveat.

- **Opponents scored less against New England than they did against everyone else**, by 3.1 points a game, the biggest gap in the league (Baltimore and Pittsburgh, the era's great system defenses, are right behind). That's the plainest measure of a good defense, adjusted for who it played; it doesn't by itself prove *game-plan* defense. An offense that holds the ball for long drives also lowers the other team's scoring.
- **The opponent's best receiver got less of the ball**. Over these seasons a team's top receiver drew about 24% of its targets. Against most defenses, that share hardly moved. Against New England it fell by 1.3 percentage points, the largest drop of any defense and about three times the next team's. That's small per game (a target or so) but it is exactly the fingerprint Lombardi's line predicts: a defense that aims at "what their individual players do best" should push the ball away from the opponent's best player, and this one did, for nineteen years.
- **The end of the half belonged to the Patriots**. The situational habit shows up as almost a point a game in a two-minute window, second only to Pittsburgh.

None of these is enormous, and none should be: they're averages over hundreds of games against every kind of opponent. What's striking is that one team sits at or near the end of all three lines.

How opponents responded

Every scheme in this course creates its own counter, and Belichick's had several.

Make the plan irrelevant with four rushers. The first two teams to beat Brady and Belichick in a Super Bowl, the 2007 and 2011 Giants, did it the way 11-04 describes: a four-man rush good enough to reach Brady without blitzing, with linemen pushing up the middle where a pocket passer can't escape. A game plan on offense can hide a weakness from a coordinator, but not from four defensive linemen who win their matchups on every play. The 2015 Denver defense did it again in the AFC Championship

Game, hitting Brady 20 times, the most on any quarterback that season.²⁷

Have too many best things. A plan that takes one thing away works best against an offense with one thing. The 2017 Eagles in Super Bowl LII spread the ball among receivers, tight ends and backs, and their backup quarterback played the game of his life; there was no single target to take away. The great quarterbacks who beat New England, Peyton Manning in the 2006 and 2015 AFC title games, later Patrick Mahomes, could beat a defense “left-handed”, throwing to whoever was left.

Take away *their* best thing. Defenses turned the method around: bracket Gronkowski, double Welker, press Edelman, and dare the second and third options to win. The Patriots’ answer, again and again, was to change which player was the best thing that week.

Hire his assistants. The most direct response was to hire the people who knew how the plans were built. Romeo Crennel, Nick Saban (the Browns’ defensive coordinator under Belichick), Eric Mangini, Charlie Weis, Josh McDaniels, Bill O’Brien, Matt Patricia and Brian Flores all became head coaches, and so did his former linebacker Mike Vrabel. Their records were mixed, which is itself a lesson: the plans came from a *process* (the film work, the weekly installs, the players chosen to absorb them), and a coordinator who leaves takes the habits but not the building.

What survives

Almost all of it, and much of it has become ordinary.

- **Every defense game-plans now.** Weekly, opponent-specific defense was Belichick’s signature in 2001. By 2026 it is simply how the league works: coordinators build a disguise package and a set of matchup rules for each opponent, and the rise of two-high, rotate-at-the-snap defenses (The Modern Era) is the LIII plan as a league-wide style: show one picture, play another. The clearest recent example sits on the other sideline from New England. In Super Bowl LX in February 2026, Mike Macdonald’s Seattle defense sacked Drake Maye six times and beat the Patriots 29–13. New England’s head coach that night was Mike Vrabel, a linebacker on Belichick’s first three Super Bowl teams, with Josh McDaniels calling the offense.²⁸ (Macdonald’s defense gets its own case study in From Two-High to Macdonald.)
- **Versatile players over specialists.** Defensive backs who can play corner, safety and slot; linebackers who rush and drop; tight ends who block and run routes. A game plan is only as flexible as the players who have to learn it, and Belichick’s roster-building made that the priority it is now.
- **Situational football as a subject.** Teams now carry analysts for fourth-down, two-point and clock decisions (see Win Probability and Fourth Downs), and practice end-of-half and end-of-game situations weekly.
- **Concept language.** The Erhardt-Perkins way of naming plays (concepts, not formations) survives in many offenses, including McDaniels’s in New England in 2026.

Belichick left New England after the 2023 season. He became head coach at the University of North Carolina for the 2025 season, which ended 4–8, and in the January 2026 vote, his first year of eligibility, he was not elected to the Pro Football Hall of Fame, a result that drew wide criticism.²⁹ One of his game plans is there already: the handwritten Super Bowl XXV sheets.

²⁷AFC Championship Game, January 24, 2016: Denver 20, New England 18. “2015–16 NFL playoffs,” Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2015%E2%80%9316_NFL_playoffs. The 20 hits, per the official box score and the most on any quarterback in a game that season: “Brady absorbs 20 hits in AFC title game loss to Broncos,” NBC Sports Boston, <https://www.nbcsportsboston.com/nfl/new-england-patriots/brady-absorbs-20-hits-in-afc-title-game-loss-to-broncos/345224/>.

²⁸Super Bowl LX, February 8, 2026, Levi’s Stadium: Seattle 29, New England 13, with six sacks of Drake Maye; New England’s 2025 staff with Mike Vrabel as head coach and Josh McDaniels as offensive coordinator (course fact sheet; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LX). Vrabel played for New England from 2001 to 2008: Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/V/VrabMi00.htm>.

²⁹North Carolina’s 4–8 2025 season, ending with a 42–19 loss at NC State on Nov. 29, 2025: Associated Press, “Bill Belichick’s 1st season at North Carolina ends in a rivalry loss at NC State and just 4 wins,” <https://www.click2houston.com/sports/2025/11/30/bill-belichicks-1st-season-at-north-carolina-ends-in-a-rivalry-loss-at-nc-state-and-just-4-wins/>. The Hall of Fame vote (first reported by ESPN; fewer than the 40 of 50 votes needed; the class of 2026 was announced Feb. 5 without him): Josh Dubow, Associated Press, Jan. 28, 2026, via GBH, <https://www.wgbh.org/news/local/2026-01-28/bill-belichick-snubbed-by-pro-football-hall-of-fame-in-first-year-of-eligibility-report-says>.

🔍 Watch for it on Sunday: the take-away test

Pick one game. Before kickoff, write down the answer to Belichick's first question for **each** offense: what does it most need? A player (its star receiver, its running back), a concept (play-action off the run, the quick game), or a part of the field (the deep middle, the perimeter run)?

Early in the game, watch the defense on that team's first few snaps:

- Where is the star? Is a second defender near him (a safety over the top, a corner outside, a linebacker underneath)? That's a bracket, a take-away.
- How many defenders stand on the line before the snap, and how many actually rush? A defense with six on the line and four rushers is hiding something.
- Does the coverage look the same before and after the snap? If the picture changes, the defense is disguising: it's aiming at the quarterback's pre-snap read.

At halftime and at the end, check your note. Did the star get his usual share of targets or carries? Who got the ball instead? Was the thing the defense conceded (the run? the short throw? the other receiver?) the thing that beat it, or the thing it could live with? A defense that "gave up" 120 rushing yards and won may have been paying a bill it chose on Wednesday.

Predict the play

🔍 Predict the play 1: the key, turned around

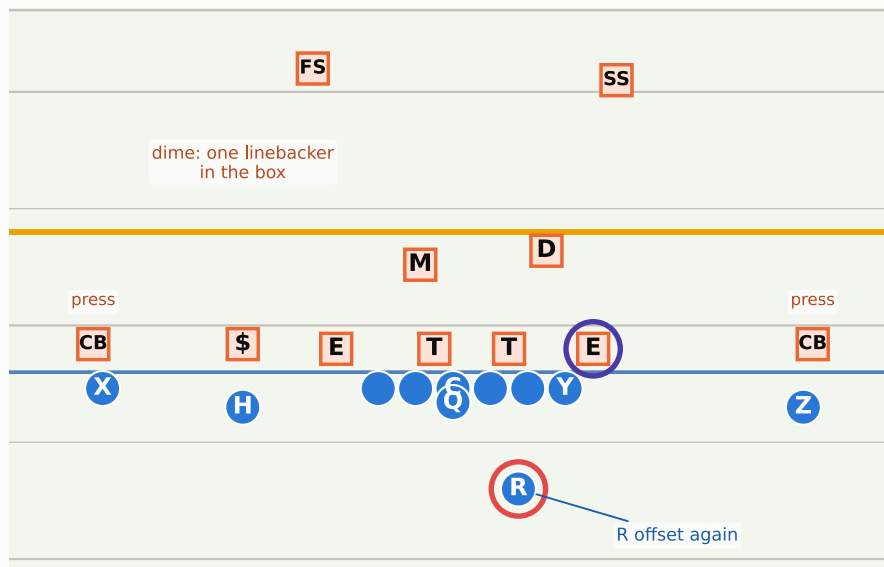


Figure 9: Third quarter, second-and-6 near midfield. All game this defense has keyed on the running back's alignment, the way New England did against Faulk: back directly behind the quarterback means run, back offset means pass. Against an offset back it has been in dime (six defensive backs, one linebacker, M), pressing the receivers, with the end on the back's side (E, purple ring) crashing on him whenever he releases. The offense lines up with its back offset again (R, red ring), the same look as on the pass plays.

The defense has been right all game about what the offset back means. What should the offense call now, and why?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: frozen in nickel

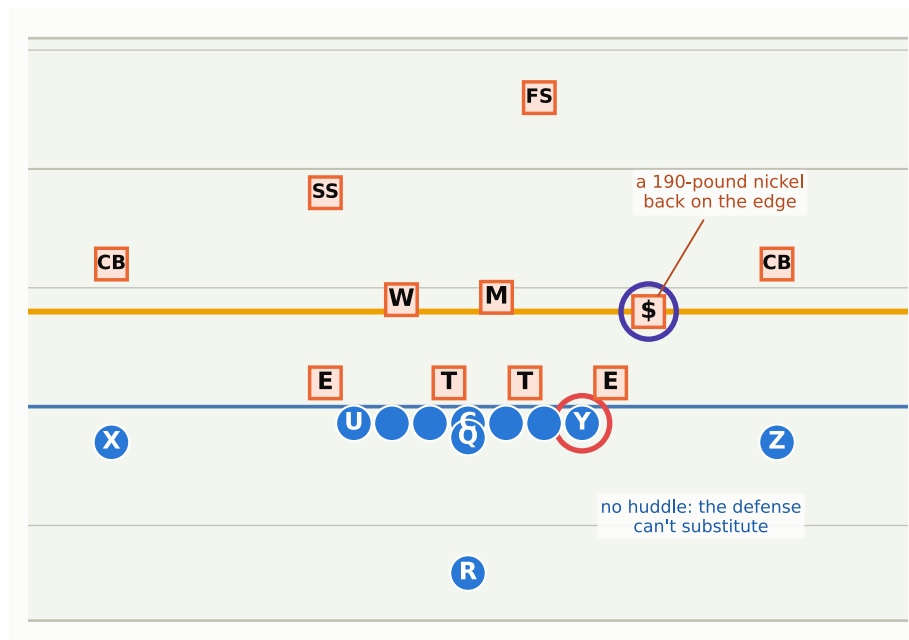


Figure 10: Second-and-4, first quarter. On first down the offense had two tight ends on the field, its star tight end (Y, red ring) split out wide, and the defense substituted to nickel to cover him (the nickel back, \$, purple ring). Now the offense has hurried to the line without a huddle, so the defense can't change personnel, and it has lined up tight: both tight ends attached to the line and a back seven yards deep.

What's the offense going to do, and why did it skip the huddle?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: fifty-eight seconds

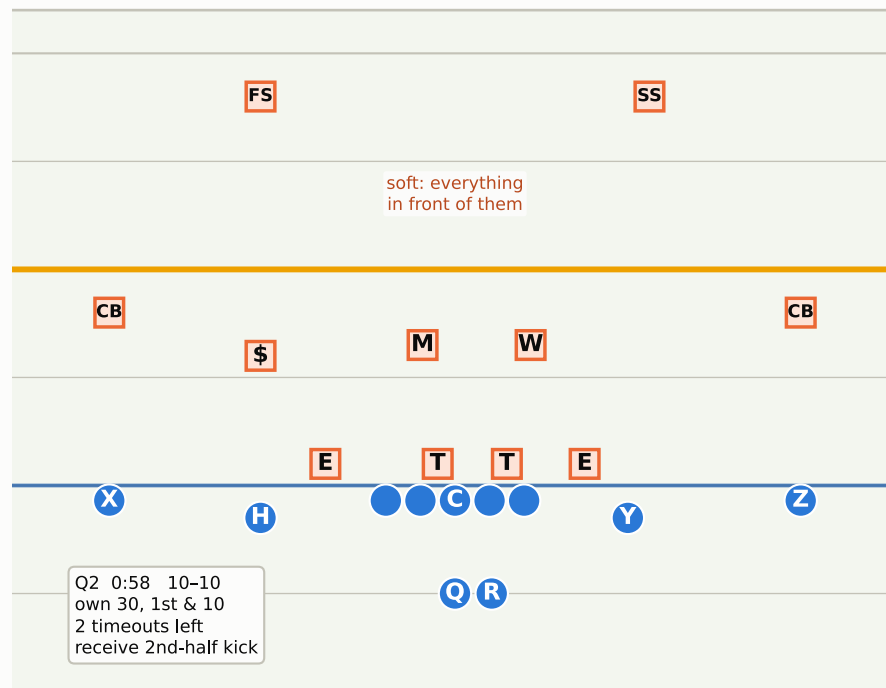


Figure 11: Second quarter, 0:58 left, tied 10–10. The offense has the ball first-and-10 at its own 30 with two timeouts, and it will receive the second-half kickoff (it won the coin toss and deferred). The defense has gone to a soft two-deep shell: two safeties deep, the corners off, linebackers and the nickel dropping to the sticks.

Many coaches would kneel and take the tie into halftime. What did Belichick’s teams usually do here, and why?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **A game-plan defense chooses its weakness every week.** Eleven defenders can’t stop everything, so Belichick’s defenses asked what *this* offense most needed, took that away, and named in advance what they’d concede. The concession is part of the plan, not a failure of it.
- **The target is usually a person.** Kelly’s passing (and Thomas as a receiver) in Super Bowl XXV, Marshall Faulk in XXXVI, Goff’s pre-snap read in LIII. In 2001–2019 data, the opponent’s top receiver lost more of his share of the targets against New England than against any other defense.
- **Each plan looked nothing like the last.** Two linemen and six defensive backs; a defense keyed on one running back’s alignment; six on the line with zone behind after a season of man. What repeated was the method: three questions, asked fresh each week.
- **The offense was a chameleon for the same reason.** A concept language that works from any formation let the Patriots throw 54 times one playoff week and run 39 times the next, and turn Gronkowski into a personnel dilemma the defense had to solve before seeing the formation.
- **Situations were rehearsed like opponents.** End-of-half drives, intentional safeties, letting a team score, the eligibility rules, the clock at the end of Super Bowl XLIX: the Patriots treated each as something to prepare, and the close-game and end-of-half numbers show it.
- **Super Bowl XLIX was decided by preparation, not by the call.** A defensible pass met a jam and a jumped slant that New England had rehearsed that week against that formation.

Connections

Builds on: Dynasties and Counterpunches (the Patriots in the 2000–2016 arms race, the move tight end and the four-man rush that beat them); The Game Plan: A Week Inside an NFL Building (the week, the tendency report and “take away their best thing”);

What Beats What (why every coverage has holes); Man Coverage (brackets and shadows); Personnel Groupings (the substitution order behind every dilemma in this chapter); The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down and Red Zone, Goal Line, and Short Yardage (the situational plays and the stack rub in full).

Sets up: The Modern Era (disguise and two-high defense as the league-wide version of the LIII plan); the other case studies, especially The Shanahan Tree (the system McVay ran in Super Bowl LIII, seen from the offense's side), Andy Reid's Chiefs (the offense with too many best things) and From Two-High to Macdonald; Win Probability and Fourth Downs (the math behind situational decisions); and Tendencies, PROE and Charting (building fingerprints like Figure 8 for any team).

Go deeper

David Halberstam's *The Education of a Coach* (2005) is the essential biography: Steve Belichick's scouting, the Giants years, and how Belichick learned to think about opponents. Michael Holley's *Patriot Reign* (2004) and *War Room* (2011) were written from inside the building; Ian O'Connor's *Belichick* (2018) is the fullest life; Michael Lombardi's *Gridiron Genius* (2018) explains the process from a former colleague's chair. NFL Films' *Do Your Job* (2015) covers the 2014 season, including the week of practice behind the Super Bowl XLIX interception. For data, start with this chapter's code: change "NE" to any team in the fingerprint cell and see where your team sits on each line, or point the [LIII](#) comparison at any defense and any game in the 2018–2025 participation files.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

A run from the pass look: a draw or an inside run, or a screen to the back that uses the end's crash against him. Every key a defense uses is a tendency the offense can scout, and once the offense knows the defense trusts it, the key becomes a lever (the tendency breaker of Constraint Theory). Look at what the key has bought the defense: six defensive backs and one linebacker, corners pressed on the outside, an end flying upfield. That's a light box. A draw, with the linemen showing pass and then blocking the rushers where they've chosen to go, puts the back against one linebacker and a safety. A screen to his side lets the crashing end run himself out of the play.

Two notes. On second-and-6 a 4-yard run is a fine result, so the offense isn't risking much by testing the key. And the defense's coaches know this too. A good game-plan defense keeps the key for most of the game and then *shows* the key while playing something else, a base front against the offset back, say, on the down it expects the tendency breaker. That's why Belichick's 2001 staff changed so much between the regular-season meeting and the Super Bowl: they expected the Rams to adjust to what they'd seen in November.

Answer 2.

Run right, at the nickel back, with the star tight end blocking him. This is the dilemma from Figure 6 with tempo added. First down was the question: what do you do when our tight end splits out? The defense answered by sending on a nickel back, a defensive back of about 190 pounds, in place of a linebacker. Now the offense has kept the same eleven players, lined up as a running formation, and snapped the ball before the defense could send its linebacker back on; a no-huddle offense that never substitutes can hold a defense in the wrong personnel, the substitution freeze of In-Game Adjustments. The defense has seven players near the line against seven blockers plus the back, and its edge player on the right is the smallest man on the field, facing a 265-pound tight end. That's a run play's dream.

If the defense keeps answering with base personnel instead, the offense splits the tight end out again and throws at the linebacker. The table in Panel D of Figure 6 is the whole game. (The Patriots of 2011–2012 played this way for long stretches; 11-04 has their 2012 total of 1,191 offensive plays.)

Answer 3.

Attack, carefully: throw underneath the soft shell, get out of bounds or use a timeout after each completion, and aim for field-goal range. The arithmetic is the "double score" from The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down. Fifty-eight seconds and two timeouts is enough for four to six plays. A defense playing this deep gives away 8- to 12-yard throws in front of it, and two or three of those reach the opponent's 35, a long but makeable field goal. Then, because this offense deferred the coin toss, it gets the ball again to start the second half. Two possessions in a row, separated only by halftime, can turn a tie into a 10-point lead in a few minutes of game time.

The risk is a turnover deep in your own territory, which is why the throws are short, the sideline is used, and nothing goes up for grabs; if the first two plays go nowhere, the right call becomes the kneel. The Patriots made this sequence a habit. In 2001–2019 they outscored opponents by 0.84 points a game in the last two minutes of the first half, second in the league (Figure 8). It's the same thinking as Super Bowl XXXVI's last drive, from your own 17 with no timeouts: a situation rehearsed in practice is a situation you can attack.